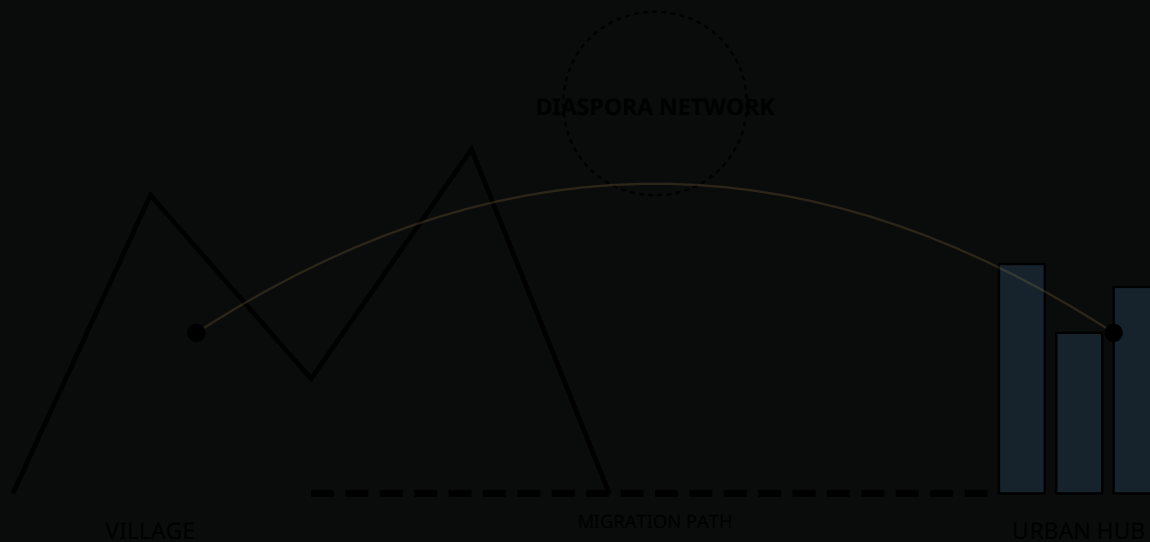


MIGRATION & URBANIZATION

“Leaving home does not always mean leaving identity behind.”

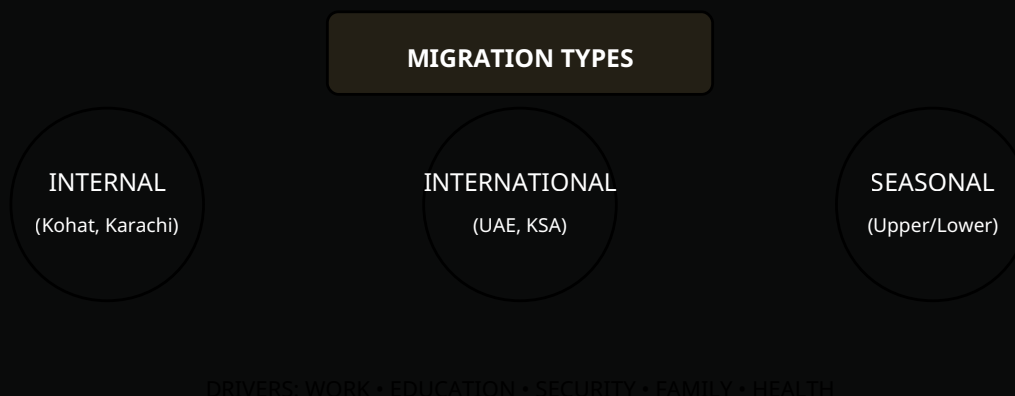
People do not always leave home because they have stopped loving it. Sometimes they leave because opportunity is elsewhere. Sometimes they leave to study. Sometimes to work. Sometimes to find healthcare. Sometimes because conflict makes staying impossible. And sometimes migration begins with one family member leaving and eventually becomes a network connecting an entire community to a city. For Orakzai, movement has never been only about geography. It is also about memory. A person can build a new life in a city while continuing to speak Pashto at home. A family can move away while maintaining relationships with relatives in the homeland. A young person can study in an urban centre while carrying the identity of the village. Migration changes where people live. It does not necessarily determine who they are. Urbanization therefore creates a different question: How does a community remain connected when its people no longer live in one place?



“The trans-local bridge between the Orakzai highland and the urban world.”

WHAT IS MIGRATION?

Migration refers to the movement of people from one place to another. In the Orakzai context, it is a survival and advancement strategy. It ranges from seasonal pastoral movement between upper and lower valleys to long-distance international labor in the Gulf. These categories are not mutually exclusive; a family may have one member working in Karachi, another studying in Peshawar, and others managing the ancestral land in Orakzai.^{5 6}



“The diverse modalities of Orakzai mobility.”

WHAT IS URBANIZATION?

Urbanization in Orakzai is a dual process. It involves the physical movement of people to established cities like Peshawar and Karachi, but it also involves the administrative and economic transformation of local settlements. The growth of Kalaya as a district headquarters and Ghiljo as a commercial hub represents a "local urbanization" that changes the character of the homeland itself.^{2 7}

RURAL → TOWN (Kalaya) → CITY (Peshawar) → URBAN NETWORK

“The continuum of Orakzai settlement transformation.”

THE 2023 DEMOGRAPHIC SNAPSHOT

The 2023 Digital Census records a population of 387,561 for Orakzai District. While the census classifies the district as 100% rural in its locality tables, this statistical designation masks the emerging urban functions of its primary administrative and commercial centers. The population density of 252 persons per km² reflects a society highly concentrated in accessible valley floors.¹

387,561

TOTAL POPULATION (2023)

52,104

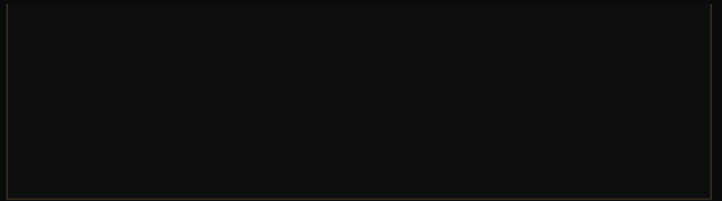
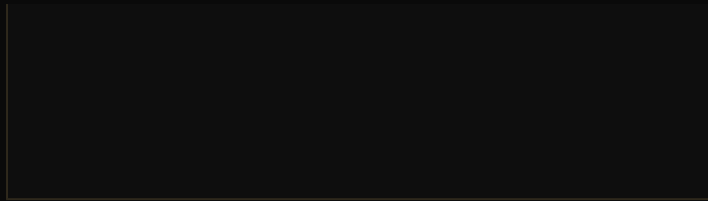
TOTAL HOUSEHOLDS

100%

RURAL LOCALITY CLASSIFICATION

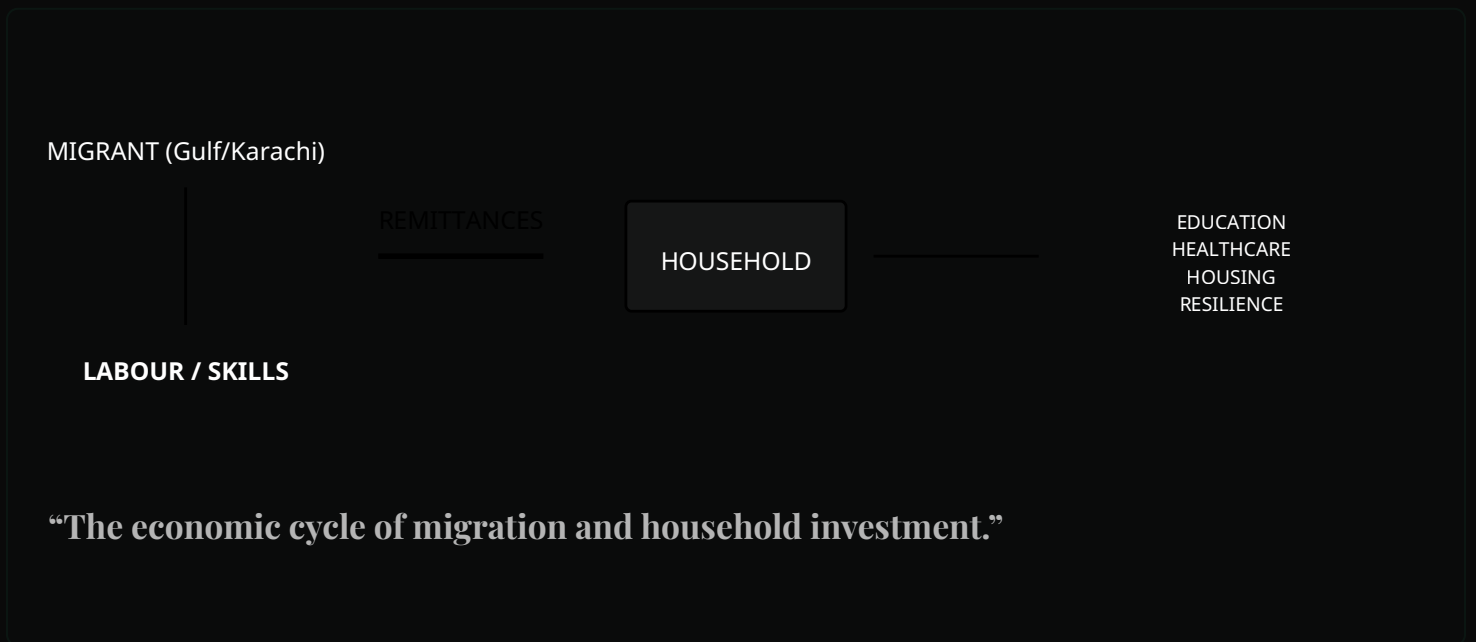
252

PERSONS PER KM²



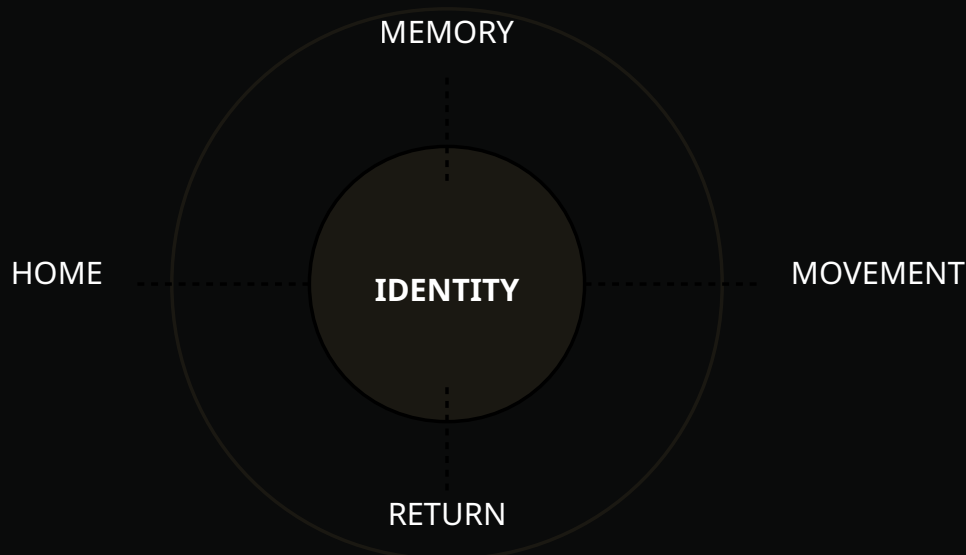
MIGRATION & REMITTANCES

For many Orakzai households, migration is an economic necessity that yields vital remittances. These funds are not merely for consumption; they are invested in the human capital of the next generation—paying for school fees, healthcare, and the construction of permanent housing that symbolizes the family's success and resilience.⁵



THE TRANS-LOCAL IDENTITY

Being Orakzai is no longer defined solely by residence in the mountains. The identity is carried into the streets of Karachi, the classrooms of Peshawar, and the labor camps of the Gulf. This trans-local identity is maintained through a "memory of return"—the enduring social and emotional connection to the ancestral village that remains the ultimate reference point for every Orakzai person.⁶



“The psychological and social components of trans-local Orakzai identity.”

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Migration is often seen as a loss—a loss of people, a loss of culture, a loss of connection. But in Orakzai, I see it as a form of resilience. When a young man leaves for Karachi or Dubai, he is not abandoning his mountains; he is building a bridge to them. He carries the language of his elders into the city and sends the fruits of his labor back to the valley. The dream of returning to the village often fuels the hard work in the city, even if that return is only for holidays or retirement. Being Orakzai is not about where you stand; it is about where your heart is anchored. Our mountains are not just a place; they are a perspective that we carry wherever we go.

“BEING ORAKZAI IS NOT ABOUT WHERE YOU STAND; IT IS ABOUT WHERE YOUR HEART IS ANCHORED.”

